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Wendell Brunious — Part II

Wendell Brunious joined Monk Rowe, Director of the Fillius Jazz Archive for a second interview at the Paradise Valley Jazz Party in Scottsdale, Arizona on April 16, 2000. Since his last interview in 1995, Wendell has toured steadily with the Preservation Hall Jazz Band and appeared as a soloist at numerous jazz parties and festivals across the country.

MR: We are in Scottsdale, Arizona, and I am very pleased to have for my guest for the Hamilton College Jazz Archive my good friend Wendell Brunious, straight from New Orleans via many different places, you've been telling me.

WB: Oh boy, I've traveled so much. It's been very, very tough. But you just take something good out of it and just keep going.

MR: How is the Preservation Hall jazz thing going?

WB: That's going very, very well. It's a nice thing to be part of, just carrying on a musical tradition that's very much worth carrying on. Even though I like a lot of other forms of music, the people who can carry that music on should take some responsibility of doing so.

MR: What's the average age in that group now, besides yourself?

WB: Well the average age used to be about 75 in that band. But now I would think it's around 45 now. 45 to 50.

MR: Yeah?

WB: Yeah.

MR: Are there any of the kind of original fellas left?

WB: Well there's just a few original people but not active anymore. The last person was Mr. Narvin Kimball, the left handed banjo player. And he had a stroke a couple of months ago so he's inactive now. But hopefully, maybe he'll come back and just sing a few songs with us, and just stay active that way. That would be really, really nice to have him back. But he's 91 years old now. So if you have a stroke when you're 91, that's tough.

MR: What's New Orleans like as a jazz center now? Is it at all?

WB: Well there's a lot of stuff going on there. One of the main things I don't like about the New Orleans thing is they're not really like progressing musically. They're playing little like B flat licks, you know, but they're not really progressing like for playing changes, playing different keys and stuff like that. We don't have enough kids trying to do that. We have the kids in the colleges who aren't the street smart type of musicians, so they're getting the education but they can't play the street music. Then we have the street guys who don't go to school so they're not really playing like a real educated higher form of

music. So I'd like to see more people like in the middle between these two things then, separated so far.

MR: Your family is musical I know. Does it go back a ways?

WB: Oh yeah. Well it goes back actually my Uncle Willie Santiago was one of the first guitar players of jazz, working with like Buddy Bolden and like Bunk Johnson and people way, way back. Because my mother's family, her father's family was from Santiago, Chile. And they had come to New Orleans to perform and decided to stay there. I guess it was a heck of a trek to get to New Orleans from Chile in — this was about 1873 or something like that. I mean so then after the gig is over you've got to go back. I don't know how long it took to get there but my goodness, no one was inspired.

MR: No way — they went to New Orleans to just play?

WB: To play, to do a show or something.

MR: Oh my God.

WB: And they were classical musicians mostly. There was no jazz then, so everybody read and just played by the paper. And like they got to New Orleans and it was like some ragtime going on there and kind of funky butt music. My mother's family was really instrumental in forming jazz that way.

MR: Wow. How much documentation do you have on it, anything?

WB: Not much. It's hard to even comment on stuff like that because it's so difficult to find information on that. But we have people re-writing history every day all of a sudden now. They're taking things that they can't really prove, that's kind of rumors and stuff like that, and documenting it as the truth, and that's a little bit scary. So it's hard — you know this is like what my old Uncle Willie had told like my mother and them when they were kids, how they got to New Orleans. But it's not documented so this is the first time I'm ever saying that. Because I can't really prove it.

MR: And they had no idea that they were perhaps part of making some musical history, they were just working.

WB: Yeah. They were just working and creating and doing what they felt comfortable doing. That's great though man.

MR: And the Brunious family of musicians?

WB: Yeah.

MR: Is that any relation to your last name?

WB: Yes. George Brunious, Mary Brunious and Abby Brunious and those guys, they were kin to my grandfather but coming from like a Creole family, things were so divided. You know whoever could, we had what we call pasa blanc Creoles, which means we're white Creoles and there was so much opportunity on that side man. I mean you can't blame

which one do you go for man? So people who could go for caviar went for it, and some of them got away with it and, great. So I mean you can't really blame anybody for trying to better their own condition.

MR: What does the name Brunious—

WB: Brunious. Yeah. Our family came from a city in southern France called Pau. And our original name, Brunoix, B-R-U-N-O-I-X. So then that got to be B-R-U-N-O-I-S. But then it got kind of Americanized, Brunios, and then there were different forms of spellings after that, so that people could pull their magic act let's call it. So it's just, things just go like that. And sometimes it's really tough to talk about because you've got people who say oh no, it didn't go like that because everyone will believe whatever they want to believe and it's okay. So I try to most of the time avoid stuff like that.

MR: Wow. Well I really don't know a heck of a lot about how you got into this music, and I'd really enjoy finding out. I know your father was quite musical and a writer.

WB: My dad was a great trumpet player. His dad had played piano, which was George Brunious' cousin John, and his name was John Brunious also, my grandfather, he played kind of like piano and when my dad was about in second grade, Willie Humphrey — you know of him? The clarinet player? Willie Humphrey?

MR: Um hum.

WB: He was teaching at Craig School, Joseph A. Craig, and that's when my dad was going to school, so Willie talked to my grandfather about getting my dad an instrument. He said, "Man, you know, that kid's got some talent somewhere man, you should get him an instrument." So they bought him a trumpet and he really progressed on trumpet. So he had gotten skipped two grades, so he graduated from high school when he was 15. And he went up to New York with my cousin, Harold Dejan. You know of him?

MR: No.

WB: Who has the Olympia Brass Band. That was my dad's first cousin. And he went up there and he auditioned for Juilliard and he won a scholarship to Juilliard. So when he was 16 he was at Juilliard. And by the time he was 19, I don't know if he had graduated or if he had left, I don't know what the thing was, but my mom's mother had died so he came back to New Orleans, they got married, and he started touring with, I think it was the Jay McShann band at first. And he wrote some arrangements, Charlie Parker was in the band, and a few guys. Then he went with the Cab Calloway band when Dizzy Gillespie did the whole spitball trip? Cab hired my daddy, when he got rid of Dizzy Gillespie.

MR: Oh gee, I didn't know that.

WB: And I used to say that to Diz sometimes, and Diz would say, "Man, I went on to be famous, I'm glad — they could take that job man." So just imagine. And then he worked

trumpet player in the *Down Beat* poll. And he got arthritis in his legs and he couldn't walk for two years. And I mean if you have three kids at home and you can't walk for two years, you know, I mean writing arrangements — I don't know what arrangements paid back in the 40s some time, but it just, you know like decimated his whole economic situation. So he never really got back from that. He did pretty well but he never got to that step. I mean he died of a broken heart. He just always wanted to get back there. But it just never worked for him — having kids, responsibilities and you know.

MR: Did he continue to play in New Orleans some?

WB: Yeah he played a lot with like Paul Barbarin, Uncle Lester Santiago played piano in the band, and when my dad first came back, my uncle was like, "Man you'd better learn to play some of this music." And my dad wasn't playing traditional music at all. So he and my uncle Lester used to practice together. They lived on Villere Street in the Tremaine. That's where my uncle used to live. And my dad said he would go over there just about every day, they'd go over a few songs and that's how he met my mom, practicing with my uncle, and it's kind of nice to know those things like that. But I kind of grew up listening to my older brother play trumpet, boy he was a killer trumpet player. Art Blakey came and wanted to hire him in his band but I don't know exactly what happened but he didn't go. Man, I was like this is what you've been practicing for your whole life. John would have been a major star on trumpet. That guy can really play man. I mean he was like, like all that Clifford Brown stuff, but with the Miles cool thing, and all the chops. He used to practice to all the Maynard Ferguson records, so he could hit all those high notes. This guy was incredible. And I mean when he was a kid, you know my dad was young then so he was really on him to practice a lot. When he was 15 this guy played "Flight of the Bumblebee" for his recital. I mean this is really great stuff that this guy could do. But I grew up listening to him and he had a lot of Dizzy Gillespie records and Clifford Brown quite naturally, Miles. And I mean I always heard traditional music and I played with Olympia. I used to go and sit in with them when I was a kid, from 14 until I was about 17. And first I played in rock bands, I used to try to imitate like Lew Soloff's solos on "Go Down Gambling" and all that.

MR: He was here this weekend.

WB: Yeah. It was very nice to see him. I told him all about that. He was like, me? I said yeah, you. But in 1976 Albert Papa French, who took over the band from Papa Celestin, which was like the oldest established band in the world, continuing like from 1910, he called my dad to make a job. And my dad said, "Albert, I'm sick, but I'll send my son." So he was like, "Okay man." Well Papa French thought he would send John, my older brother you know. And I walked in there, at that time I had my big Jimi Hendrix tall hairdo, you

says, “Who are you man?” I says, “I’m Picket’s son man.” And he says, “Oh wait, we thought he was going to send John, man.” Well my whole ego just took a nosedive. He said, “But I’ll tell you what, you know some songs?” I said, “Yeah I know a few songs, I’ve been practicing a little bit.” So he says, “Well look I’m going to make you my band leader. Whatever you call tonight, that’s what we’re going to play.” And then, what a relief that was. And I learned a lot that night, just about being a band leader. Because if you take the weakest link and make that your stronger link, you won’t have any problems, because you can always cut back, you can’t always get this guy to go ahead. So that’s what we did. And man, I did very well on that first night. And I knew a few songs and he did a few things that he sang and I got to play. I could play form, I just didn’t know a whole lot of melodies. So that was a really great learning experience.

MR: What kind of tunes did you call at that time?

WB: Well quite naturally, we did “Milenberg’s Joy,” that’s the first song we did. I kind of knew it. I didn’t really know the melody but it was kind of like “Bourbon Street” form so I could follow it. And I had an old record with Kit Howard when he did “I Wish I Could Shimmy Like My Sister Kate,” and “Sugar Blues,” “What Can I Say Dear After I Say I’m Sorry,” what else was on that — oh “Coconut Island.” Songs like this. It was a wide array of songs. And Papa was like, “Yeah man, you’re doing good man.” And I knew a few hymns, you know “Closer Walk With Thee,” and “By and By,” from playing with the brass bands. So I did actually pretty well. And he sang a couple of tunes, “Embraceable You” and stuff, which I kind of knew of, I couldn’t really play that kind of stuff then. But it was — I just kind of did my best. And I got paid. That was important.

MR: All right. At that point, how old were you, 1976?

WB: I was about 21.

MR: Okay. Had you decided on a musical career?

WB: Well I was still in business school. My dad sent me to business school. He said man, I think he was under the impression I was going to get a real job one day you know. And so I was still in college actually. And I wanted to play music but I was just thinking I have to be serious about business if I’m going to get a degree in it, knowing in the back of my mind I don’t want to do this man, I want to play trumpet. So I had kind of made up my mind but I still had to focus on getting my business degree because that’s what my dad said I was supposed to do. And that was it. But it worked out pretty well.

MR: What was the entrance into the music field that kind of cemented your — okay I’m going to do this — or was there one?

WB: Well when I was about — just before I started playing with Papa French, I was about 19, and I went on Bourbon Street and I heard some of those guys play, and I wasn’t really

little time under my belt. So that was very inspiring that this guy had a job and I could actually do that. So then I knew I could do it, I was a business major majoring in distributive education, DE. And in DE you had to have a job, because it's like a management course. So I had a little job at Sears. So I was going to school full time, I was working at Sears plus playing a few little rock gigs here and there, and this guy used to come in and buy fishing equipment. I had no idea who he was. And then one day Herlin Riley, you know him?

MR: Yes.

WB: The drummer? He and I grew up like brothers. I mean I was the best man in his wedding. And he came in Sears one day and he says, "Hey what are you doing working here, man?" I said, "Well it's part of my college course and I have to do it." He says, "Look I'm working a job on Bourbon Street as a trumpet player, but I want the job as the drummer." He said, "Why don't you come take this job as the trumpet player?" And I was like, "You play drums?" I didn't even know he played drums then. He was like, "Yeah." I said, "Oh come on, man." He said, "I'm telling you man, I play drums." So I said okay. So when I went to the audition that night, the guy who was the band leader was this guy who used to come buy the fishing equipment from me. And he was like, "You work at Sears?" I said, "Yeah." It was such a coincidence. Well it wound up I got that job, it was at the 500 Club, playing for a strip tease show.

MR: All right.

WB: And this guy, his name was Vladimir Vasiliev, and he had gone to Berklee in Boston and studied with Margaret Chaloff. Come to find out Lew Soloff was his first trumpet player when Lew was about 19 or 20 years old. And I was telling Lew this story, and he was like, "My God man, I had forgotten about Vladimir." But that kind of — then I started making a little money and then it was like hey, I could actually make a living doing this. So Vladimir had a great Latin band, which he had like Al McKibbon and Don Alias and Bobby Rodriguez, and all these guys were in his band, Manny Duran. And so we formed a Latin band in New Orleans, The Aquarians was the name of the band. Vladimir and the Aquarians. And then we started growing. He had some beautiful charts that he had written [scats]. Just to play those phrases man was preparing me for futuristic. I didn't realize it then I was just doing it, I was just making the job. But that was great preparation. Then like I got the call from Papa French and I just kind of played some gigs. In 1979 I played on the New Orleans Jazz Festival with Lionel Hampton. Wallace Davenport was in the band so he called me and he says, "Hey man, can you read?" I said, "Yeah, I can spell a little bit." So he was like, "Well look, Lionel Hampton needs a trumpet player for the night man, you want to make the job?" So I said yeah. So we had a

called Wallace and said, "Hey, who's that boy that you had down there?" So Bill Titone called me and Wallace says, "Look, whatever kind of money they offer you, take it. That's an experience that you can't buy. Just take the job man." He says, "Just take the job. In the future you're not even going to think about it but it will help you so much." So I did about five months of staying in the YMCA in New York.

MR: No kidding.

WB: Oh my goodness. And we used to travel a lot.

MR: Because Lionel didn't pay like a heck of a lot.

WB: Well he paid weekly, very weakly. But it was okay. You know there were some great guys in the band. Curtis Fuller was in the band, Ricky Ford, Frankie Dunlop played drums. Man. Zeke Mullen. Sometimes we had Teddy Wilson on piano, and George Wein sometimes on the piano and Josho Maruda, you know of him?

MR: No I haven't heard of him.

WB: The alto player? And sometimes we'd have a guest spot with Illinois Jacquet, Lockjaw Davis, Arnett Cobb, man. Sometimes all three of those guys would be there, man, and they'd play "Lady Be Good," gee I'll never forget it. But boy I used to look forward. Because that was about 20 minutes but man did those guys do some head cutting in there, oh boy, whew.

MR: Tough Texas tenors.

WB: Yeah. Those guys, but boy I looked so forward. I would just wait for Gates. He'd say "bbbboys 'Lady Be Good.'" Oh man, I would get so excited.

MR: He's still at it you know.

WB: Yeah. And he would practice. Because where I stayed, it was at 63rd and Broadway. And he stayed on 64th and Broadway at Lincoln Plaza. And I used to go up to his house every day. And he would go through some stuff. He was an old man then, he was about 76 or something, 75 or 76. And he was still practicing 4 to 5 hours a day. And one time we went to Detroit at the Pontchartrain Hotel. And then Gates called "Giant Steps." And Bags had come up there with his vibes. First they did this "I've Got Rhythm" thing, I think it was Hamp and Dex we used to call it, Eric Dickerson — not Eric Dickerson, who was the tenor player?

MR: Eric Dixon.

WB: Eric Dixon, yeah. I'm thinking Eric Dickerson the football player. Eric Dixon had done an arrangement that Dexter Gordon and Hampton had done on that, and boy —

MR: On "Giant Steps?"

WB: It was "I've Got Rhythm," Gates stepped in. And they did that first. And Bags played really well. But boy then Lionel Hampton really wanted blood. He said, "Kid get out that

and oh my goodness. And Bags was like, you know Bags is a great bluesy player, but he didn't play those kinds of changes. Man, Gates just wanted blood man. But it was so exciting though. You know we'd have a ride from New Haven to, I don't know, Chicago or somewhere like that. As soon as you get out of the bus — Gates would fly — hey man, you're on the bus 15 hours. And he'd say, "It's time for a rehearsal." So I mean you'd get out there dog tired, red eyed, and 15 guys on the bus with one urinal, you know.

MR: Funky butt.

WB: Yeah. But it was all part of it. And that was a great experience. Wallace Davenport was right, he was right. He said, "Man, no matter what kind of money they offer you just take it." So yeah, it was a great, great opportunity and preparation. So I kind of started like substituting for different people. I did a lot of European trips. Chet Baker and I had the same manager, Vim Vict from Vhagony & Holland. So he had booked me some nice gigs over there, you know some traditional gigs, some kind of swing gigs and bop gigs and stuff like that. Then I kind of started traveling with the Preservation Hall band like really about 1987. I had done a few trips with them before that but it's when the old guy Percy Humphrey really started getting old, I started doing more and more touring with them. But I still enjoy getting out on my own. I mean that's the kind of house buying job which we all need, thank God they're there sometimes. But sometimes you want a little more freedom of expression and sometimes it works, sometimes it doesn't.

MR: Have you ever led your own group for any length of time?

WB: Yeah. I mean I still have a band that I tour with now. I just call it the Wendell Brunious New Orleans All-Stars. We've toured all through Germany. I had a beautiful two weeks in Korea that I brought my band on and we did a CD from that, and it was really, really great, I mean really great. And Freddy Longo tours with me and he's a really great trombone player. I had Charlie Gabriel, who is from New Orleans but he lives in Detroit now, he left New Orleans with the Fats Navarro kids band, like way back in '47 or something like that. He's a great player and great guy. And I have Thaddeus Richard who used to be the saxophone player with Paul McCartney and Wings, and he's a great piano player. His daddy wrote a lot of stuff with Ray Charles, Reynolds Richard. He wrote "I've Got a Woman" and a few things like that. I wish I was getting that royalty check. And Mark Brooks is my bass player. Sometimes I use Shannon Powell who is a really great drummer from New Orleans. He was Harry Connick Jr.'s drummer with the big band, and he didn't go back when Harry redid his thing. But he tours with me sometimes, and sometimes Gerald French, and we just try to make the best music we know how to make.

MR: What's the music that this particular group plays? How do you describe it to potential

WB: To potential markets I would just — high quality music I would call it. We do a lot of standards and I try to keep that New Orleans feeling happening in some things because that's a pretty unique thing. I mean most people from Dover, Delaware or somewhere like that are not going to know anything about a New Orleans groove. Those guys may play some facsimile of Bebop but to get that kind of New Orleans groove, I mean that's a pretty unique thing throughout the world actually.

MR: Can you put it into words?

WB: Well just a two feel, with a really kind of Gospel type of beat. This is kind of like the triangle I try to play within. I don't know if you could hear the whole thing but I try to go [percussive claps]. So the whole New Orleans concept is within that. Because if you think like [sings "Saints"]. Even Fats Domino [sings "I'm Walking.] You see? So it's all based within that, that whole New Orleans concept is based within that. And so we try to keep that element quite naturally, even though we don't play that all night. But I love playing standards, ballads, and just grooving. Because boy, we've got so much music that comes from the brain anymore in the world, that sometimes the groove is not exactly there.

MR: Too much brain and not enough—

WB: Too much brain and not enough heart. So I try to keep the heart in there. And if you get all these real complex forms and stuff like that, the brain will creep in there, the brain will. So that's why I like to keep it a little more simple and very melodic. Because I mean I'm liable to go on the job and play anything from "Careless Love" to "Moment's Notice." But it would still be with a kind of groove that I respect.

MR: The music business these days: there must be highs and lows throughout the year for you.

WB: Yup. So thank God I have a business degree, and you just learn to manage your money and manage yourself and conduct yourself—

MR: So there was some use in that thing there.

WB: Some use there, just conduct yourself in a nice manner. But I've gotten to play with some of the greatest man. I mean that CD we did together, you had some of the greatest people on there — Bill Watrous, Jerome Richardson, Keter Betts, yourself.

MR: Oh thank you.

WB: Yeah, we had a really, really great time doing that. You did some really fantastic music.

MR: Well I wanted to ask you about a little thing here that you played. Let's see if I can kind of capture that.

[audio interlude]

MR: That's beautiful, a beautiful solo man. You like it?

WB: Yeah.

MR: Because you should.

WB: Yeah. That feels good. That's what music is supposed to feel like. That's called a Brownlick. That's where I got that from.

MR: Clifford Brown lick?

WB: Clifford Brown.

MR: Yeah?

WB: It's like coming down a major third and then two half steps and then up a major third back down to the major third two half steps. So it's based on a whole tone. And Clifford Brown used to wear that thing out, he just did it so fast and so clearly, then he'd do it backwards you know? So I mean I did it coming down but he'd [scats], do it up, down, sideways, he could just do anything on the instrument, yeah.

MR: Well this music hadn't been something we'd been able to work on a long time, so can you see that coming when you're reading the changes, can you see a place where that lick's going to work kind of? Or is it not so well thought out as that?

WB: No. I don't think I'm that smart. I couldn't think that far ahead.

MR: Well I didn't say that was smart, okay?

WB: No but everything was grooving so well. Dennis was just playing such a laid back groove. I was just watching him when we were playing, he just was so satisfied with everything that was going on, that's very inspirational and gives you confidence like that I could actually play on this without playing the triad of what I'm looking at here. So I was looking at the changes and listening maybe even more so. So I was just responding to — what was the pianist—

MR: Rick.

WB: Rick, yeah, what Rick was doing and sometimes he'd play like an inflection of a flatted something, and then it would make you — it was like I hope this works, you know. But that spontaneity it kept it fresh. That's why this sounds so fresh.

MR: Well it was a good experience.

WB: It really was. And sitting next to Bill Watrous, man.

MR: Well I think you got the spot here. There's a spot that sounds like you guys practiced it.

WB: Really, uh huh.

MR: I think it's coming up here, when you make the transition from you to him.

WB: Yeah.

MR: I mean that's seamless.

WB: Yeah it was pretty seamless. I think it's just Watrous. He just can hear man. That guy can — man can he play some sassy trombone. Boy that was such a great experience. Because Jerome was just — years and years ago he recorded a record, before CDs, an album with Gino Vanelli, where he played soprano.

WB: It was "Father and Son."

MR: Oh he's on that?

WB: That's Jerome playing that. I mean he was like playing some of the most incredible soprano I ever heard. You know my dad and I used to sit down — my dad died in '76. So they must have recorded that around '74, '75. And I mean we used to sit around and listen to that and you know my dad being like a real staunch big band, swing type of guy you know, he would say hey man, that guy's playing man, whoever it is. And I read the name, Jerome Richardson and I knew I'd heard it before. But that left a very lasting impression on me. And when I got to meet him, that was the first time I met him, when we came up there to record with you. And he was just such a great guy. It's very nice to know that your heroes are nice people.

MR: That's true. You know I hope I never read a book about like Cannonball Adderley that says he wasn't nice, because he was a nice guy.

WB: Oh man, he was a great man. He was a great guy.

MR: I don't want anybody saying anything different.

WB: At the end of his life, I went to Southern University, Kidd Jordan was our professor there, and he got Cannonball to come over to do a clinic with us. Man, it was just, boy, the real Cannonball is here man. And the maturity that was coming out of that alto was just like — you know it was a little heavy and he had a big beard at that point.

MR: Yes he did.

WB: But I mean it was unmistak— he might not look like what you remember Cannonball to look like, but when that alto started it was definitely Cannonball man. Oh my God. And he was such a great guy. I mean just like I just played this set with Clark Terry. And it was so encouraging — I'd play a lick and Clark would be like, "Yeah, man." I mean this is actually, this is not just somebody sitting in the front row there, this is Clark Terry, egging you on and just kind of supporting you and stuff. And I leaned over to him and I said, "Look, if you hear any of your licks, I'm sorry, okay?" And he got a kick out of that.

MR: You know when — I don't know how you put it into words, but you hear those, like he was playing some riffs, it was the first set before he played, and Harry Allen would pick them up. But these riffs he came up with were so uniquely him.

WB: Oh, were they.

MR: And they would take this little turn like gee if I had thought of that I would not have been able to think of that cool little way he ended that thing you know. And it's just the years. I guess it's the years. And his personality.

WB: Yeah it's just him. I mean he just — what comes out of his horn is purely Clark Terry.

mean when you hear Sweets Edison there's no doubt. I mean Charlie Shavers and him played a little bit alike. But when you actually hear Sweets Edison there's no doubt who it is [scats]. I mean you know it's coming and you're still so pleased when it happens. And that's the way it was with Clark. Because he'd have some licks going on, and just the way he would end it was so [scats]. And it would just leave you hanging like, boy, man. I hope that happens to me one day, that I can just do that like that. I mean it's easy to follow in some ways but to create it is another story.

MR: You have any unhappiness with the way jazz is being marketed or annotated or being recorded historically these days? Anything currently going on that's worrisome to you?

WB: Yeah, we don't have the blues anymore, Monk. The blues is not an element of jazz anymore. That's why I say the heart is going out of it. Because the blues comes from the heart. And you've got all these guys, they've got all the licks, you know they can play licks and make your head swim. But that blues element, because I mean the blues is in some ways like a slower way of living, you know? I mean it's a dues way man. But everybody has a publicist, and if you're 19 and you've got a great publicist and you can play a few pentatonic scales, guess what, man? You're liable to be a star man. And some guy that's paid some dues man and has been playing and working and traveling and doing all his stuff and paying the dues, if you're 45 man, it's probably not going to happen for you, you know? And that's a really horrible thought when I think about it. Because I don't think you really start to play until, you know like young Freddie Hubbard played all kinds of stuff. But a little later man, he really started. Like when he did, he was pretty young still when he did like "Body and Soul." But man did he just play. He had paid some dues. He had been like with — what's the trombone player, the left handed guy?

MR: Not Curtis Fuller.

WB: No, no, no, no. I'm going to think of it. Because Bill Fielder was telling me about that, that he and Freddie were in — Slide Hampton.

MR: Oh, Slide Hampton.

WB: They were in Slide Hampton's band together. And he said man Freddie was about 18 man, just blowing all kinds of stuff. But when he got around 24, 25 years old, he really came into his own and just was young enough with the energy to do what he wanted to do, and had a few years under his belt that he could be a little more predictable, bluesy and with a little more heart.

MR: If you had to make a short list of trumpet players that every aspiring student should listen to, and really listen to, who would they be?

WB: Okay. My first thing is whenever someone comes to me and says they want to study jazz,

Brown with Strings," and I'm going to give you a free lesson. That's always my deal. Because Clifford Brown displayed, on that CD, record, tape, whatever you have of it, how to play melody. Every song on there is a ballad. And Neal Hefti wrote some unbelievable string parts on there. And Clifford Brown just played the trumpet the way it's supposed to be played. I mean he's breathing, his accents, and just he knew when to swell a note or when to be really quiet. And you know like when he did "Embraceable You," just the first note on that [scats], the way he played that note, is like — I mean you have to listen to it, you know what I mean. People say oh yeah, yeah, well okay. But you're not listening if you think of it like that. That attack on that first note is that big man. It's just like he didn't sneak up on that sucker man. And I would think some of that early 60s Miles Davis, just about anything from Miles. "Seven Steps to Heaven," "Milestones," all of that stuff. Because that's when Miles was playing man. He really was redefining jazz. And that modal thing was just working into him. Because he had influenced musicians that he'd hired, and then they kind of influenced him, you know how that kind of went. I mean quite naturally any Dizzy Gillespie/Charlie Parker record, boy 'cause those guys, like "Groovin' High," the arrangements [scats]. And that was so defining of, hey man something is really about to happen here. And it's just kind of like prelude to Bebop. I mean it's just like, and in some ways the introduction was more complex than the tune itself. You know? Like some of those, like on "Salt Peanuts," [scats] man that's some bad stuff man. And it's like but still there's an element of blues there man. The blues is just waving at you the whole while man. And a lot of the contemporary music, I don't, I mean the blues is just like hiding in the corner somewhere. You know guys will bend a note every now and then, but it just seems like they're physically bending it, not emotionally bending it. And I don't know what that's from. I don't know where it went. But we've got people who would claim that they're really playing the blues and if that's written somewhere, the pen is more powerful than the voice or the sword or anything else. So if it's written somewhere, this guy must be doing it.

MR: Do you think that some of the younger generation got to the point where they felt the blues was denigrating to their culture?

WB: That's a good question. That's a very good question. It could be, but you know my dad used to say to me there's a reason for everything but there is no excuse for anything. So don't make that your excuse not to learn the blues. Because the blues is something real. And it's got a real place in jazz. So I mean you can hey man it's degrading or it's Uncle Tom or whatever, I mean it's just, don't use the excuse, because of that that's why I don't play the blues. When you think of Louis Armstrong himself, the dues that that guy paid

shoulders. Every one. I mean he didn't have too many, I mean he had Joe Oliver as a mentor, he had a few guys, B.A. Rolfe that he heard play, but he pretty much single-handedly revolutionized jazz and just did the whole thing man. Everything after him was affected by him. He and like Michaelangelo are like two of the greatest artists. I mean the world just was not the same after these guys. And I mean this is before mass media. Oh man, Louis Armstrong, I mean to be a black man, and I'm not talking a Creole man that could get by in the brown side of town, this was a black guy man, with very little education, came from, his mother was in black Storyville — I didn't know exactly how she made a living, she had a questionable way of making a living I say, and to become Louis Armstrong. That doesn't happen every day. It's never going to happen again as a matter of fact.

MR: Not every century.

WB: No. And so I mean the blues was good enough for Louis Armstrong man, and good enough for Charlie Parker, and good enough for Roy Eldridge and Coleman Hawkins, and Prez, and all of these cats, all the way through Miles, Clifford Brown, Diz, and then kind of all of a sudden it started to diminish when we could justify that we really wanted to get serious or whatever. And I think blues is serious man, it's very serious. Because it's something from within, not something acquired. It's a statement from within.

MR: Well I'm sure you're going to keep it alive in your own playing.

WB: Oh man, I like playing, attempting to play some more modern forms and stuff like that, but whenever I think of the way I like to play it's a very, very strong blues element in there.

MR: What's in the near future for you?

WB: Hopefully I'm going to start doing a little more travel on my own. I've got a little agent that I'm working with and he's trying to book me some stuff, and where I'm not so boxed in with the Preservation Hall concept. I mean it's a great thing to be part of, but I just have other statements that I want to make, and a few other seeds to sow.

MR: Great.

WB: Thank you man.

MR: Well it's been a great pleasure.

WB: Thank you, Monk.

MR: And I'm sure we'll cross paths again soon.

WB: Thank you. All right.